

One grammar, two agreement options: Existential *there* in New York City English

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Abstract: In this paper, we discuss optional agreement with third-person plural postverbal subjects of existential *there* clauses in New York City English. Data were obtained from the CUNY Corpus of New York City English, (CUNY-CoNYCE), an approximately two-million word corpus of extemporaneous speech from 202 participants raised in the New York City Dialect region (Tortora et al. 2025). The results of our study, along with the native-speaker grammaticality judgments of the author(s), suggest that both singular and plural verbal agreement is freely available for speakers of NYC English with 3pl postverbal subjects of existential clauses. We model the syntax of this optionally-realized agreement in terms of a single grammatical system—i.e., not as the result of multiple competing grammars (e.g., Kroch 1989, a.o.)—based in the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT) (Chomsky 2021; 2024). Ultimately, we analyze this instance of variable agreement as the result of the grammar allowing for multiple interpretable outputs generated in the narrow syntax. Additionally, this system permits language users’ extragrammatical preferences to constrain the frequency of use of optional forms based on interaction with variables such as tense. We provide a novel set of tools for analyzing cases of intra-speaker variation that cannot be clearly attributed to underlying multilectalism.

Keywords: syntax; corpus linguistics; variation; optionality; existentials; NYC English; SMT

1. Introduction

This paper concerns an alternation in subject-verb agreement that many English speakers allow with third person plural postverbal subjects—a.k.a. associates (Chomsky 1986)—of existential *there* clauses, in which speakers may realize either third person plural or third person singular agreement morphology on the verb. See the following.

- (1) a. There *were* no problems with the analysis.
b. There *was* no problems with the analysis.

While the plural agreement in (1a) is certainly the prescriptive standard in most varieties of English, many English speakers of many dialects both produce and accept the singular agreement pattern as seen in (1b). This fact has been well-noted in the literature (Rochemont 1978; Sobin 1997; Munn 1999; Schütze 1999; Crawford 2005; Tortora 2006; López 2007; Riordan 2007 Deal 2009; Collins 2012; Hilton 2016; Sturino 2017; Storment 2025, a.o.), though we believe that the distribution of the singular agreement with 3pl associates has been insufficiently explained.

Focusing on a single English dialect, New York City English (e.g., Newman 2006), we show using grammaticality judgments and a novel corpus study using the *Corpus of New York City English* (CUNY-CoNYCE) (Tortora et al. 2025) that the distribution of singular agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses is much wider than some sources have previously acknowledged, in terms of the configurations that allow it and the frequency at which it is used.

While much work on this topic treats the relevant agreement alternation as kind of aberrant quirk of English existentials, or as something that only arises under a very limited set of structural and/or pragmatic conditions, we argue that the availability of both singular and plural agreement with 3pl associates is a general property of NYC English existential constructions for speakers who allow both options, and that such agreement optionality is a stable feature of individual

grammars of speakers of this dialect (Krejci & Hilton 2015). We thus defend the idea that language contact (multilectalism) and language change are not necessary to explain the presence of this agreement optionality in NYC English existentials, a view that is supported by our corpus study. We present a novel view of optionality that accommodates these considerations based in the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT) (Chomsky et al. 2019; Chomsky 2021; 2024).

Our data further support the idea that variation in use of these optionally-available agreement forms in this construction in NYC English is highly idiolectal, shaped by individualized preferences (Ormazabal & Romero 2024; Lowe & Wu 2026) rather than sporadic alternations between distinctly-acquired categorical agreement rules in the language users' internal grammars.

Examples in this paper that do not come from the CUNY-CoNYCE corpus reflect the grammaticality judgments of the author who is a native speaker of NYC English, and are additionally corroborated by the other author who is a non-native speaker of NYC English and a native speaker of a closely-related dialect of American English.

The paper is structured as follows: in Section 2, we discuss the syntactic properties of existential clauses that show optional agreement, showing that singular agreement is freely available with 3pl associates in NYC English existential *there* clauses, as far as acceptability is concerned. In Section 3, we discuss our corpus study, showing novel data on the distribution and frequency of singular agreement. Section 4 places the data obtained in the corpus study in a theoretical context, where we argue for an account of agreement optionality that does not rely on multilectalism and/or language change while simultaneously allowing for individualistic conditioning via extragrammatical preferences. Section 5 concludes.

2. Configurational parameters of variable agreement

While the existence of singular agreement with 3pl associates in English existential *there* clauses has been acknowledged in the literature (Rochemont 1978; Sobin 1997; Munn 1999; Schütze 1999; Crawford 2005; Tortora 2006; López 2007; Riordan 2007; Deal 2009; Collins 2012; Hilton 2016; Sturino 2017; Storment 2025, a.o.), this acknowledgement has not come without gaps. Much work on this point of agreement variation has claimed that the distribution of singular agreement with a 3pl associate is much more restricted than is the case in NYC English. We discuss some of these points in the literature—and their counterexamples—now.

First, it has been noted in the literature that singular agreement with 3pl associates is only a property of associates that involve a coordinate structure (e.g., Munn 1999). This is plainly false, as has been noted in numerous places (Meechan & Foley 1994; Schütze 1999; Riordan 2007; Hilton 2016, a.o.). Additionally, it seems that singular agreement with a 3pl associate is possible with any type of plural associate, which has been discussed elsewhere for dialects other than NYC English (e.g., Sturino 2017; Storment 2025). See the following.

- (2)
 - a. There {was/were} a problem and a solution to consider. (Coordinated associate)
 - b. There {was/were} problems to consider. (Bare NP associate)
 - c. There {was/were} many problems to consider. (Quantified DP associate)
 - d. There {was/were} no problems to consider. (Neg DP associate)
 - e. There {was/were} those problems to consider. (Demonstrative DP associate)
 - f. There {was/were} the problems to consider. (Determiner DP associate)
 - g. There {was/were} two problems to consider. (Numeral DP associate)
 - h. There {was/were} them to consider. (Pronominal associate)

Not discussing language users' preferences for the moment, it is clear that, in terms of acceptability, both options for agreement are available in NYC English for any kind of 3pl associate.

Next, there is a substantial portion of the literature which claims that singular agreement with 3pl associates is only seen with present tense contracted copular verb -'s, often called a 'frozen' form (e.g., Chomsky 1995; Sobin 1997; Crawford 2005; Deal 2009). While the grammaticality of the examples in (2) are by themselves a testament against this claim, and while this claim has been refuted, for instance, by Schütze (1997), we show here that the relevant singular agreement pattern has a much wider distribution in NYC English than appearing only with the present contracted copula. See the following examples concerning tense (3), verb type (4), and negation (5), which are also corroborated in other sources such as Sturino (2017) and Storment (2025).

- (3) a. There {is/-'s/are} several books on the table. (Present)
 b. There {was/were} several books on the table. (Past)
 c. There {has/have} been several books on the table. (Present perfect)
- (4) a. There {was/were} three men. (Copula)
 b. There {has/have} arrived three men. (Unaccusative)
 c. There {appears/appear} to be arriving three men. (Raising verb)
 d. Into the room there {walks/walk} three men (Unergative)
 e. There {has/have} to be exceptions to the rule. (Modal auxiliary)
- (5) There {is/are}n't enough bottles for the party. (Negation)

Further structural conditions that do not impede the ability of optional agreement to be realized in these configurations include raising (6) (also see 4c), the presence of a structural intervener between the verb and the (optional) target for agreement (7), and structural Case, which must be accusative regardless of agreement (8) (see Storment 2025 for a more nuanced discussion on the unavailability of nominative Case on existential associates, as well as Citko 2014:38).

- (6) a. There {seems/seem} to be several books on the table.
 b. There {appears/appear} to be several books on the table.
 c. There {is/are} likely to appear several men at the door.
- (7) a. There {is/-'s/are} allegedly several women being considered. (Adverb)
 b. There {is/-'s/are} located on the table several books. (Locative phrase)
 c. There {is/-'s/are}—it seems—no clear solutions to this problem. (Parenthetical)
- (8) a. There {was/were} {them/*they}.
 b. There {was/%were¹} {us/*we}.

¹ Concerning agreement in number with postverbal 1pl (and 2pl) pronominal associates, it is true that many English speakers who readily accept agreement with 3pl associates have much more trouble doing so with 1/2p ones, with Storment (2025) deeming agreement with 1pl associates ungrammatical across the board. It is the case, however, that some speakers do allow verbal agreement in number with a 1pl or 2pl associate. In order to see that number agreement with 3pl associates and 1pl associates is not fully equivalent, however, see the following example:

i. There *were* them and there *was* us; and he never ever saw it any differently. (Storment 2025:187)

Because we have failed to identify a structural configuration in which only singular or plural agreement is possible, we do not pursue an explanation in which one option for agreement is tied to a derivation that is underlyingly completely distinct from the other: e.g., where the associate in the singular agreement pattern moves to a position that it does not move to in the plural agreement pattern (e.g., Kayne 2016; Kučerová 2016; Sturino 2017).

In spite of these facts (which seem to hold well beyond NYC English as well as within it), many researchers seem to maintain that optionality of agreement with a 3pl associate in English existentials is some kind of peculiarity of this specific construction that must be accounted for in a way that subject-verb agreement normally is not, as opposed to a natural feature of the syntax of English (and, perhaps, of natural language in general). Examples of this kind of analysis are the ‘frozen form’ account (see above references), the analysis of plural agreement as a grammatical ‘virus’ (Sobin 1997), and the explanation of singular agreement as a processing effect (Schütze 1999). As we go on to show with our corpus study and theoretical discussion, these kinds of caveats on what the grammar allows are not actually necessary to derive the variable agreement with 3pl associates, and to not have them is actually preferable. Rather, we can conceive of a system in which both options for agreement are freely available within a single grammatical system. On this, Schütze (1999:482) says the following:

- (9) ‘Since the need for both types of structures within UG is well motivated, we should not have qualms about making this move, particularly since we thereby gain greater empirical coverage than we get by maintaining that either of these constructions is extragrammatical.’ (Schütze 1999:482)

We agree with Schütze that it is necessary to conceive of a system in which both optional structures are freely allowed by UG. While Schütze himself does not sketch such a system in detail in the cited source, this is the goal that we pursue in the remainder of the paper.

We pause here to clarify that we are crucially not claiming that speakers do not have variable preferences for optional agreement realizations across different structural configurations that their grammars allow (indeed, the data from our study show that this is exactly the case). This is not what it means for two options to be freely available in terms of acceptability. Rather, what we see here is a picture in which both singular and plural agreement are productively allowed for a single language user with no discernable contrasts in grammaticality and semantic meaning (Sturino 2017) in the same contexts, though variable degrees of realization are allowed—and, indeed, to be expected—in certain configurations over others. We discuss this point in detail further on.

Now that we have established the parameters of optional agreement according to the judgments of the authors, we move on to our study with the CUNY-CoNYCE corpus, keeping in mind the implications of the data discussed in this section.

3. Corpus study

In this section, we describe our corpus study design, implementation, and results. Importantly, singular agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses in NYC English account for a

As for why it is the case that 3pl associate agreement should be more acceptable than 1pl associate agreement, we maintain that agreement with the features of the 1pl associate creates a feature conflict with the third person feature of the existential *there* in the structural subject position (Chomsky 1981; Storment 2025, a.o.), which may create an irresolvable conflict in the grammar of some speakers. Since 3pl associates match in person features with the existential subject, there is no such conflict for third person associates.

notably large share of the tokens obtained, especially in present tense forms, and there is variable use of singular agreement across present- and past-tense forms. Additionally, the majority of the social predictors tested did not reach the level of statistical significance—though, we did find significance with birth year, which we discuss below.

3.1 Data

The dataset consists of 197 existential constructions with third-person plural noun phrase associates extracted from the Corpus of New York City English (CoNYCE). Tokens were identified from audio-aligned Praat TextGrids generated from sociolinguistic interviews with 202 speakers.

Python scripts were developed to automate preprocessing and coding of linguistic features like agreement outcome, contraction, and tense.² Regular expressions were used to target six types of existential constructions (*there is*, *there's*, *there are*, *there be*, *there was*, and *there were*), along with the spaCy library to match them with subsequent tagged plural and proper plural noun phrases. Only present- and past-tense existential constructions exhibiting overt agreement morphology were included in the analysis. One token of *there be*, which lacked overt tense and agreement morphology, was excluded.

Each token was coded for agreement outcome, with singular agreement (*there's*, *there is*, *there was*) coded as 1 and plural agreement (*there are*, *there were*) coded as 0. Speaker-level predictors included year of birth, gender, and household language background. To reduce sparsity, multilingual speakers were grouped into broader sociolinguistically motivated categories: English-only, Spanish-background, European, East/Southeast Asian, and Other multilingual.

Overall, singular agreement occurred in 46.2% of existential constructions with plural noun phrases, indicating that it is a productive variant in New York City English. However, the markedly different distributions observed across tense domains motives separate considerations of present- and past-tense constructions (see section 4.3).

3.2 Methodology

Agreement variation was modeled using mixed-effects logistic regression with a binomial logit link implemented in lme4 in R. Year of birth, gender, and household language background were included as fixed effects, while speaker was included as a random intercept to account for repeated observations. The response variable was coded as singular agreement (1) versus plural agreement (0), with all models including the following fixed effects:

(10) Fixed effects model

Formula:

Outcome ~ Year.of.Birth + Gender + Household.language.background +
(1 | speaker)

An initial combined model additionally included tense and contraction. However, contraction and tense produced quasi-complete separation because contracted *there's* occurs exclusively in the present tense. Consequently, the primary analyses fit separate models for present- and past-tense constructions, while the combined model is retained for descriptive comparison.

² Full repository of programs used can be found at <https://github.com/sbhowan/conyce-existentials>.

Model performance was evaluated using speaker-level variance, intraclass correlation coefficients (ICC), and conditional and marginal R^2 . Predicted probabilities for social predictors were generated using 95% confidence intervals.

3.3 Results

Here, we outline in detail the results of our corpus study, which ultimately feed into a novel theoretical understanding of agreement variation in NYC English existentials (Section 4).

3.3.1 Differences between tense domains

The descriptive statistics reveal substantial differences between tense domains. Singular agreement occurred in 66.7% of present-tense existential constructions but only 27.0% of past-tense constructions, indicating that the two tense domains exhibit notably different distributions of agreement behavior.

Table 1: Comparison of present- and past-tense existential agreement.

Property	Present tense ($N = 96$)	Past tense ($N = 100$)
Singular construction	64 (66.7%) <i>there is/'s</i>	27 (27.0%) <i>there was</i>
Plural construction	32 (33.3%) <i>there are</i>	73 (73.0%) <i>there were</i>
Dominant agreement pattern	Singular	Plural
Social conditioning	Weak	Weak to moderate
Speaker-level conditioning	Diffuse	Stronger

As summarized in Table 1, the present-tense pattern is characterized by high rates of singular agreement and relatively weak social conditioning (meaning that the social predictors tested were relatively less significant). Additionally, we describe the ‘speaker-level conditioning’, which refers to the extent to which a speaker’s own internal grammar consistently favors one linguistic variant over another, as diffuse in the present tense, meaning that members in the speech community show relatively uniform behavior regarding the distribution of plurals in the present tense (see Table 2).

On the other hand, the past-tense pattern noticeably shows lower rates of singular agreement overall. While still showing weak social conditioning, the past-tense pattern shows stronger speaker-level conditioning, which means that individual language users within the speech community show a relatively higher degree of variance with respect to one another in their use of singular agreement forms in the past tense with 3pl associates (again, see Table 2).

We expound on some of these findings below.

3.3.2 Chi-square test

A Pearson's chi-square test of independence showed a significant association between tense and agreement pattern, $\chi^2(1, N = 196) = 30.99$, $p < .001$. Singular agreement was substantially

more frequent in the present tense (64/96, 66.7%), whereas plural agreement predominated in the past tense (73/100, 73.0%).

The association was of moderate magnitude (adjusted Cramér's $V = .39$, 95% CI [.27, 1.00]), providing further support that tense has a meaningful association with agreement variant.

3.3.3 Fixed effects

The mixed-effects models provide little evidence that broad demographic variables apart from year of birth systematically condition existential agreement.

As shown in Figure 1 and Table 2, year of birth significantly predicted singular agreement ($\beta = 0.023$, $SE = 0.008$, $OR = 1.02$, 95% CI [1.01, 1.04], $p = .004$). The positive log-odds coefficient indicates that later-born speakers had greater odds of singular agreement, consistent with an apparent-time increase in the use of singular existential forms. Each one-year increase in birth year was associated with approximately a 2.3% increase in the odds of singular agreement, holding gender and household language background constant. Expressed over a ten-year difference in birth year, the model's odds ratio predicts approximately 26% higher odds of singular agreement for speakers born a decade later ($OR = e^{10(.023)} \approx 1.26$).

This birth-cohort effect contrasts with gender, as shown in Figure 2, which was not a significant predictor ($p = .608$). Most household language background contrasts (Figure 3) were likewise nonsignificant, although speakers from European-language households (including Italian, German, and Yiddish) used singular agreement at significantly lower rates relative to the English-only reference group ($OR = 0.12$, 95% CI [0.02, 0.92], $p = .042$). Additionally, speakers from Spanish-background households consistently showed higher predicted probabilities of singular agreement than speakers in the remaining groups, though this effect did not reach traditional significance thresholds³.

However, household language background as a factor overall did not explain agreement variation. Although the European-background contrast was nominally significant, this isolated contrast should be interpreted cautiously given the nonsignificant overall effect of household language background.

³ We believe that this finding can be related to the observation that, in Spanish existentials, the prescriptive tendency in many varieties of Spanish is for verbal agreement to be singular in existential clauses with a 3pl associate. Regarding this point, though, there is a considerable amount of variation across different language varieties and language users (Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2008). Given these complexities of variation, and the fact that this paper is about a specific variety of English, we leave a more detailed discussion of the possibilities of Spanish-language influence of NYC English existentials aside for now.

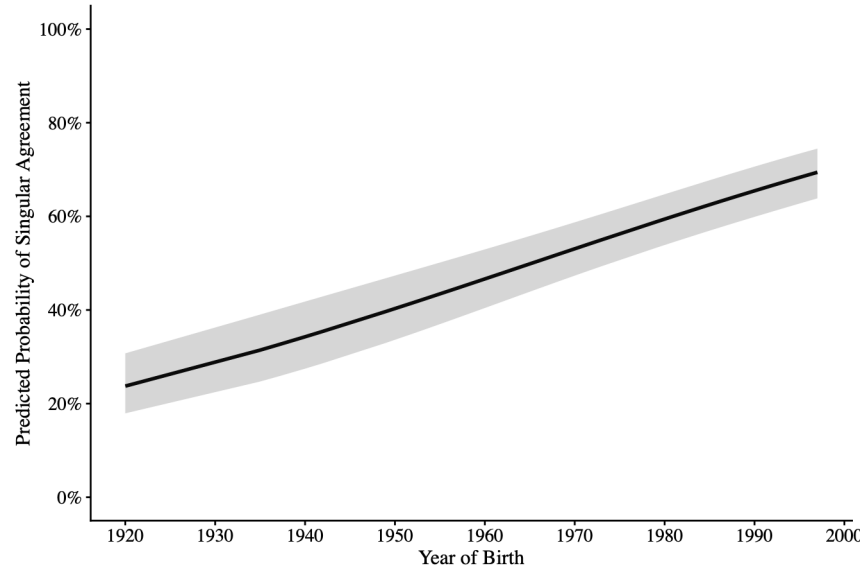


Figure 1. Model-predicted probability of singular agreement by year of birth.

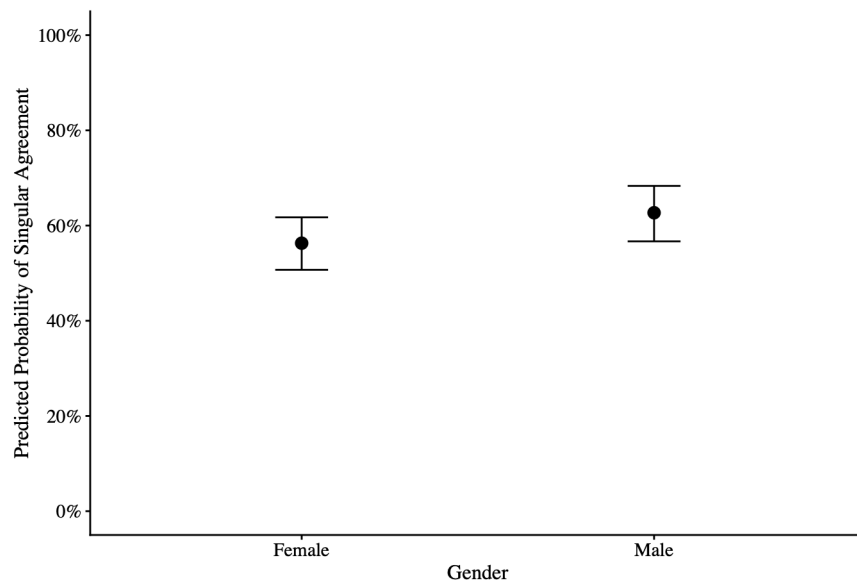


Figure 2. Model-predicted probability of singular agreement by gender.

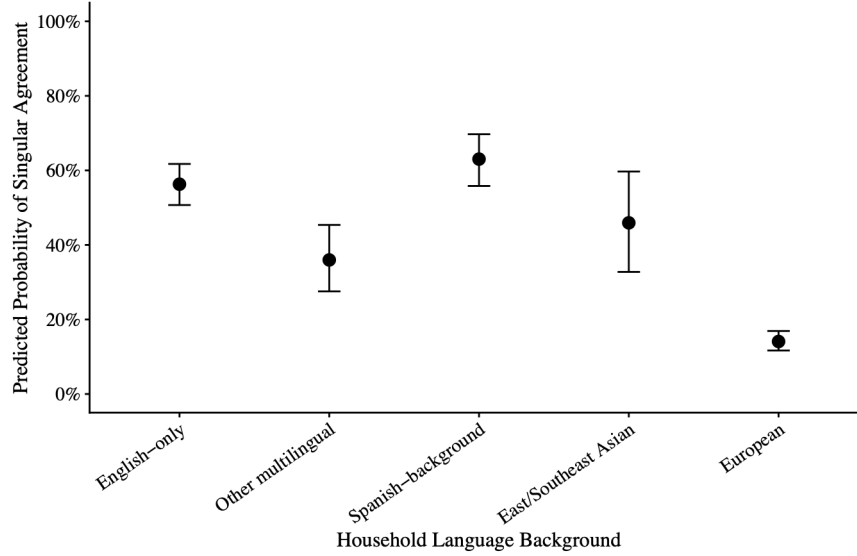


Figure 3. Model-predicted probability of singular agreement by household language background.

Table 2: Fixed-effect estimates from the mixed-effects logistic regression model predicting singular agreement.

Predictor	OR	95% CI	<i>z</i>	<i>p</i>
Year of Birth	1.02	[1.01, 1.04]	2.86	.004
Gender (Male)	1.38	[0.41, 4.65]	0.51	.608
Other multilingual	0.43	[0.06, 2.98]	-0.86	.392
Spanish-background	1.30	[0.28, 6.03]	0.33	.738
East/Southeast Asian	0.66	[0.05, 8.17]	-0.32	.748
European	0.12	[0.02, 0.93]	-2.04	.042
<i>Random effects and model fit</i>				
Speaker intercept variance	2.70	Marginal R^2		.125
Conditional R^2	.520			
<i>Sample size</i>				
Observations	149	Speakers		81

Note: OR = odds ratio; CI = confidence interval. Marginal R^2 represents variance explained by the fixed effects; conditional R^2 represents variance explained by the fixed and random effects. Reference levels are Female for gender and English-only for household language background. Forty-nine observations were excluded because at least one model variable was missing.

In a likelihood-ratio test, adding household language background did not significantly improve model fit relative to a model containing year of birth, gender, and a random intercept for speaker, $\chi^2(4) = 6.00$, $p = .199$. Consistent with this result, both AIC (197.61 vs. 199.60) and BIC (209.62 vs. 223.64) favored the simpler model without household language background, meaning that it does not improve the model's ability to explain or predict agreement variation.

While birth cohort significantly conditions singular agreement, substantial speaker-level variation remains after demographic predictors are taken into account. Thus, demographic conditioning is selective, as gender and most household-language contrasts showed no reliable effects. This suggests that agreement variation is only weakly associated with most broad demographic characteristics. As demonstrated by the random effects, variation is more strongly attributable to individual speaker differences.

3.3.4 Random effects

In contrast, the random-effects structure revealed substantial heterogeneity across speakers. As shown in Table 3, the random intercept variance associated with speaker nearly doubled between the present-tense (0.95) and past-tense (1.77) models, indicating greater dispersion in speakers' baseline preferences for singular agreement in the past tense. This pattern is also reflected in the intraclass correlation coefficient (ICC), which increased from .225 to .350. Thus, approximately 22.5% of the variance in present-tense agreement is attributable to stable differences between speakers, compared to 35.0% in the past tense. The combined model yielded an even larger speaker variance (2.70) and ICC (.451), indicating that speaker identity accounts for nearly half of overall agreement variation when both tense domains are considered jointly.

Table 3: Comparison of mixed-effects logistic regression models by tense.

Model	Tokens	Speaker variance	ICC	Marginal R^2	Conditional R^2
Present tense	79	0.95	.225	.069	.278
Past tense	70	1.77	.350	.121	.429
Combined	149	2.70	.451	.125	.520

Note. Speaker variance refers to the speaker random-intercept variance ($\sigma^2_{\text{speaker}}$); ICC = intraclass correlation coefficient.

Conditional R^2 similarly increased across models (.278, .429, and .520), suggesting that the full mixed-effects models accounted for substantially more variance when speaker-specific effects were incorporated. Additionally, the combined model had a marginal R^2 of .125 and a conditional R^2 of .520, meaning that the fixed effects accounted for a relatively modest proportion of variation in singular agreement, whereas the model including both fixed effects and speaker-level random variation accounted for over half of it. The difference between marginal and conditional R^2 , together with the relatively large speaker random-intercept variance and ICC, suggests considerable between-speaker heterogeneity in agreement behavior.

Although year of birth showed a significant population-level effect, much of the variation in agreement remained associated with differences among individual speakers. In other words, not only is agreement variation more strongly conditioned by individual speakers in the past tense than in the present tense, but individual preferences for these grammatical variants also account for considerably more variation than the demographic predictors examined here.

3.4. Interpretation

We interpret our corpus study's results as indicating that existential agreement with 3pl associates in NYC English is structured primarily by individual preferences rather than broad demographic

categories. Although singular agreement accounts for nearly half of all existential constructions with plural noun phrases, in part due to the audio format of the corpus, which captures more instances of spontaneous speech than more heavily edited text corpora, its distribution differs sharply across tense domains, which we interpret as evidence that language users' individual preferences around use of these optionally-realized agreement variants are sensitive to grammatical variables such as tense. In other words, the preferences are not for the agreement forms alone, but for the agreement forms in the context of some other variable. We return to a discussion of the role of these kind of preferences in the following section.

Our results contribute to a body of literature showing that singular agreement with plural associates in existentials is actually quite abundant, even across tense domains (Meechan & Foley 1994; Smallwood 1997; Crawford 2005; Pietsch 2005; Riordan 2007)—in other words, the contracted present tense form *there's* is plainly not the only way to realize singular agreement with a plural associate (as has been claimed by Chomsky 1995, a.o.). The specific fact of variable agreement across tense domains has been noted elsewhere (e.g., Smallwood 1997), and our results show that NYC English existential agreement exhibits this property as well.

Though our results show that most of the social predictors tested have not reached statistical significance regarding agreement variation with 3pl associates, our results surrounding year of birth as a social predictor do show a straightforward and significant tendency for singular agreement to be more common among younger language users (see Figure 1). While this fact on its own may suggest that singular agreement with 3pl associates in English existentials is a kind of linguistic innovation or change-in-progress appearing among younger languages users, which has indeed been suggested elsewhere in the literature (e.g., Collins 2012; Hilton 2016), we do not believe that our results support this kind of a language-change account of the relevant data.

Consider the documented fact that singular agreement with 3pl associates in English existential clauses is attested going back almost six centuries. See the following examples gathered and reproduced in Storment (2025:81).

- (11) a. Also ther was men off gretare alyounce. (1450)
- b. For there ys many wordes in Latyn that we haue no propre englyssh accordynge therto. (1530)
- c. Concludinge then that as there ys two deathes the fyrst and second / in yerth and in hell: so there vs a fyrst and second resurrection. (1597)

Further, the optionality in agreement itself exhibited within a single language user is attested going back several centuries as well. See for instance the writings of George Washington, who exhibits both singular and plural agreement with 3pl associates (Washington 1748-1757).

- (12) a. There *is* three separate strings of Wampum, which the Half-King has desired me to send.
- b. There *was* 3 French Deserters.
- c. There *has* arrived two Indians from Moskingam.
- d. ...that there *were* four small Forts between New Orleans and the Black-Islands.
- e. That at New Orleans...there *are* 35 Companies, of 40 men each.
- f. There *are* also several other Houses, such as Stables, Smiths, Shop,&c.

For the existence of data such as these, we would be hesitant to attribute the presence of singular agreement with 3pl associates in a 21st century variety of English to linguistic innovation or a novel change-in-progress. In fact, the existence of these examples in (11) and (12) and the fact that we continue to find such examples today may suggest that this agreement pattern is a stable feature of the syntax of English existential constructions (e.g., Krejci & Hilton 2015), and has been for quite some time. Additionally, it is well-known that older language users tend to be more conservative in general in their use of non-standard forms for a variety of reasons (see *age grading*) (Labov 1966; Trudgill 1974; Macaulay 1977; Hughes 1992; Eckert 1997, a.o.), with singular agreement notably being the prescriptively non-standard variant for 3pl associate agreement with English existentials. As such, a change-in-progress should not be considered the only possible explanation for the more frequent use of a non-standard form among younger language users.

Language change can, of course, lead to instances of intraspeaker and intra-dialectal optionality (Kroch 1989, a.m.o.). If one were to pursue a language-change account of this specific instance of optionality, however, we should expect to see two things for which substantial evidence does not exist: first, a situation of linguistic instability overtime, and, second, evidence for multiple competing grammars integrating within a population to create multiple optional realizations of agreement.

Regarding the first point, as we have discussed thus far, it seems that optional agreement with 3pl associates is if anything a stable feature of the grammars of the relevant English(es), especially considering the attestation of such data points as (11) and (12). We can contrast this with the well-known case of the innovation of do-support in late Middle English, in which do-support completely replaced subject-verb inversion after a period of both do-support and S-V inversion being optionally permitted within a single population, but before which only S-V inversion was attested (Ellegård 1953; Kroch 1989; Ecay 2015).

We see no evidence here, however, that singular agreement is actually displacing plural agreement in any way, nor has this suggestion been brought up in any of the previously-cited experimental and/or corpus studies on variable agreement in English existentials. Was it ever the case, for instance, that plural agreement was exclusively allowed in English existentials? Furthermore, is it currently the case that plural agreement is disappearing in English existentials? We have seen no evidence that either of these statements is true, and strong evidence supporting these claims would be needed in order to definitively show that the optionality of agreement discussed here is a by-product of language change. We should thus be careful to not overshoot the implications of results concerning age in this study.

Regarding the second point of multiple competing grammars, the Kroch (1989) analysis of the innovation of do-support in late Middle English necessarily relies on multiple competing grammars converging in a single linguistic population, with the ‘newer’ grammar eventually overtaking the ‘older’ grammar—thus leading to language change. In this way, language change of this kind is necessarily linked to the convergence of multiple competing grammars within individuals and within a speech community. Given that we have not seen ample evidence for neither the claim that this point of agreement variation constitutes a change-in-progress nor the claim that either agreement realization can be reliably associated with any of the tested social predictors, we do not see sufficient evidence to connect this instance of intraspeaker variation in NYC English to the convergence of multiple competing grammars.

In accordance with Minimalist theorizing (Chomsky 1995; 2021; 2024: Chomsky et al. 2023), in the absence of compelling evidence to adopt a more complicated explanation involving the

convergence of multiple grammars to explain a single point of intraspeaker variation (in this case, singular agreement with 3pl associates in existentials), we pursue what we see as a simpler explanation that involves accounting for this point of intraspeaker variation within a single grammatical system.

In the following section, we discuss at length some theoretical issues with accounts of intraspeaker optionality of this kind that are necessarily explained via multiple competing grammars, and we further sketch a novel Minimalist system of explaining this kind of optionality without resorting to multiple grammars, which we consider to be an additional complication that is not needed in the face of insufficient evidence to adopt it as an explanatory tool.

4. Theoretical understanding

Ultimately, the results of our corpus study, along with the data discussed in the previous two sections, do not support a view in which optional agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses must be necessarily explained under an account of language change and/or the presence of multiple competing grammars converging within a single speaker (to the degree that these two notions can—or should—be teased apart). In this section, we discuss some theoretical issues with explanations of this kind of phenomena that involve multiple competing grammars. We then sketch an alternative analysis in which both singular and plural agreement are freely available in a single grammar using tools of the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT) (Chomsky et al. 2019; Chomsky 2021; 2024), in which the frequency of agreement forms allowed in the narrow syntax can be conditioned in their use by the preferences of individual language users.

We make the point here to clarify that we are *not* arguing against the existence of any instances of intraspeaker variation that are a result of multiple grammatical systems converging within a single language user: such cases certainly do exist, and it is useful to talk about them in terms of multilectalism and language contact. Rather, we argue that the case of variable agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses in NYC English does not behave as such, and we gain greater empirical coverage and theoretical understanding by divorcing our understanding of this specific instance of optionality from the existence of multiple competing grammars.

4.1. Concerning multiple grammars

Intraspeaker variation and optionality of any kind is often conflated with the presence of multiple grammars converging within a single language user and ‘competing’ with one another to produce variation (Kroch 1989; Embick 2007; Tortora 2014; Polinsky 2025, a.m.o.). As such, optionality is often conflated implicitly or otherwise with the mixing of more than one language variety in a single speaker (Kroch 1994; Grohmann et al. 2020; Procentese et al. 2024), which we can equivalently call multilectalism, or multilingualism involving two closely related language varieties. While these accounts work well to explain cases of optionality that do arise as a result of multilectalism, they pose issues for cases in which optionality cannot be so clearly tied to underlying instances of multilectalism (and we must take great care to distinguish the two cases).

There have long been issues within Minimalist syntactic theory regarding the handling of cases of apparent optionality in natural language (see relevant discussions in Adger 2006; Biberauer & Richards 2006; Riordan 2007; Fernández-Serrano 2022). This issue is in no small part due to the way in which Minimalism views natural language grammars as a discrete set of categorical ‘rules’ that are applied to generate a given meaning, deviation from which is typically understood to result in ungrammaticality (as opposed to another well-formed utterance). On this, see discussions and issues pertaining to the *axiom of categoricity* (Fischer 1958; Chomsky 1965; Chambers 1995).

In cases where linguistic variation can be explicitly associated with certain social demographic factors (e.g., Labov 1963; 1972), it makes sense to connect intraspeaker variation to the acquisition of more than one grammatical pattern connected to a given speech community. In the absence of such connections, though, the task of explaining intraspeaker variation becomes more challenging.

According to the judgments of the authors (and corroborated elsewhere; e.g., Sturino 2017) there is no discernable semantic or pragmatic difference between *There were problems* and *There was problems* in our English(es). We thus know that we are dealing with cases of true optionality. Regarding the assessment of whether or not this kind of optionality can be associated with multilectalism, our corpus study shows clearly a lack of meaningful connection between agreement tendencies and any of the social factors tested in NYC English. There is perhaps a perceived difference in register between the two agreement forms—i.e., a more formal register shows a stronger preference for only plural agreement—though other corpus study results show that formal registers still tend to display a relatively high degree of singular agreement with 3pl associates (40-48%) (Riordan 2007). Therefore, even if one is to consider different registers as distinct grammatical systems that a language user must acquire, there is no direct evidence that these different registers consist of distinct categorical rules that converge within a single language user to create intraspeaker variation, since there is no immediate reason to suspect a contrast in the possibility allowed by the grammar for agreement realization in formal versus informal registers.

Thus, to explain the case of optional agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* constructions in NYC English in terms of a language user having acquired multiple grammatical systems and switching between them seems suspect in the absence of empirical evidence demonstrating that these agreement variants are associated in any way with distinct language varieties. Furthermore, positing multiple grammars to explain every single instance of intraspeaker optionality (which is really quite a ubiquitous phenomenon in human language), especially when those optional realizations cannot be clearly connected to an identifiable language variety, seems to come at the cost of significant theoretical complication to a model of language acquisition and linguistic cognition, though we do not pursue these issues in detail here.

These issues that come with positing multiple grammars to explain every case of intraspeaker variation within a Minimalist framework have not gone unnoticed by others; in fact, multiple systems have been proposed as an alternative (e.g., Adger 2006; Biberauer & Richards 2006). One particular alternative, proposed first (as we can tell) in Adger's (2006) 'Combinatorial Variability' framework, purports to rely not on multiple grammars, but on a single grammar allowing optionality because it contains multiple variants of the same lexical items, each with distinct properties (i.e., features) that trigger distinct behaviors in the grammar. This kind of approach has recently gained major traction in the explanation of intraspeaker variation and optionality (Adger 2006; Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2008; Georgi 2017; Puškar 2017; Hoover 2021; Fernández-Serrano 2022; Driemel 2025, a.o). Despite being proposed as a Minimalist alternative to a multiple-grammars approach, we argue that these featural-variation approaches are ultimately burdened with the same theoretical complications that come along with the multiple-grammars explanations.

Featural-variation approaches such as Adger (2006), though he does not address variable agreement with existentials specifically, would capture the optionality discussed in this paper in terms of multiple underlying variants of a single subject: for instance, a version of the existential

structural subject *there* that has a [Singular] feature and another that has a [Plural] feature⁴. Similarly, Rodríguez-Mondoñedo (2008) explains variable agreement with plural associates of Spanish existential clauses in terms of a language user having access to multiple variants of a lexical item T: one that contains an unvalued feature that probes for [Number], and one that does not. While Adger identifies the point of variation as the subject and Rodríguez-Mondoñedo identifies the point of variation as the verbal inflectional head, both analyses are unified in that they explain the variation in terms of variable featural specification in the lexicon.

Adger (2006)—and elsewhere: i.e., Adger & Smith (2005)—is explicit that such an approach does not necessarily assume that a speaker has access to multiple competing grammars. Conversely, Rodríguez-Mondoñedo (2008) adopts equivalent explanatory technology that he does explicitly connect to the acquisition of multiple grammars (see his fn. 19). We assume that the assumptions of Rodríguez-Mondoñedo are more on the right track here, as we do not see how a featural-variation approach can be totally divorced from a multiple-grammars approach, as is attempted in Adger (2006).

To make this point, it is worth pondering for a moment what we even should even mean when we talk about multiple grammars in a Minimalist framework. Consider the Borer-Chomsky Conjecture (Borer 1984; Chomsky 1995; Baker 2008):

- (13) *The Borer-Chomsky Conjecture* (Baker 2008:353)
 All parameters of variation are attributable to differences in the features of particular items (e.g., the functional heads) in the lexicon.

Given our Minimalist understanding of the uniformity of syntactic operations within UG, we ought to assume that specific grammatical operations—e.g., Merge, Transfer, and so forth—operate in a universal manner (Collins & Stabler 2016; Collins 2017). What triggers distinct syntactic behavior is not variable specification in the mechanisms of the operations themselves, but rather the variable specification in the features that they operate over. For example, the difference in whether or not a language has a requirement for an overt preverbal subject (the EPP) does not come down to some fundamental difference in the way that External or Internal Merge operates over subject arguments in a language, but instead is explained by variation in the featural composition of some inflectional head such as T⁰ in a given language (Chomsky 1981; Rizzi 1982; Holmberg 2010). In other words, in a Minimalist framework, the ‘rules’ of the grammar itself are not variable (this is, at least in part, what we mean when we talk about UG); instead, the featural makeup of the objects that these ‘rules’ operate over are subject to crosslinguistic variation, thereby leading to variable ‘outputs’.

Thus, given the implications of (13), it seems that the multiple-grammars approach is actually reduced to a version of the featural-variation approach in which different featural variants of a lexical item are acquired from distinct language varieties. Additionally, it is not clear how one could go about totally divorcing the featural-variation approach from the idea of having acquired multiple grammars, given that featural variation of particular lexical items is precisely what defines separate linguistic systems. There is also a question to be asked of the featural-variation approach concerning how multiple variants of a single lexical item would be acquired without the assumption of multiple grammars, especially when a single lexical item within a given language variety is defined in terms of its featural specification.

⁴ There are slightly different approaches to the featural specification of this existential that would basically amount to the same thing here. Alternatively, one could likely play with multiple underlying variants of the featural composition of the associate itself to arrive at the same result.

Ultimately, we see that strict adherence to both the multiple-grammars and featural-variation approaches to optionality necessarily conflates intraspeaker variation with a language user having access to multiple linguistic systems, explicitly or otherwise. We note here that it is indeed very possible for a speaker to realize both optional forms of this existential agreement pattern within a single utterance. We find the following perfectly grammatical, and such attested examples are discussed at length elsewhere (e.g., Storment 2025).

- (14) a. There are multiple solutions, isn't there?
b. There's multiple solutions, aren't there?
- (15) a. There are and always has been tons of people who love you.
b. There is and always have been tons of people who love you.

Under such approaches that posit multiple linguistic systems to motivate the existence of each optional realization, the underlying mechanism to produce an utterance containing both variants is tantamount to code-switching. There is, then, an obvious question to ask of whether or not it is reasonable to claim that the utterances in (14) and (15)⁵ involve code-switching.

While there is perhaps no immediate reason to rule out code-switching in an abstract sense here (aside from the lack of evidence of multiple language varieties to begin with), we are hesitant to adopt the idea that code-switching could produce free grammatical variation in this way, given that it is well-established that code-switching is syntactically constrained (Wentz & McClure 1977; Woolford 1983; Clyne 1987). It is additionally unclear that code-switching and bilingual grammars in general are best conceived of as the convergence of multiple grammars in a single language user that may be freely switched between to produce variation (see *integrationist* models of bilingual grammars: e.g., MacSwan 1999; 2000; López 2020; Gosselin 2021; Lohndal & Putnam 2024).

Furthermore, it is well-known that code-switching is able to encode several kinds of linguistic information—such as topicalization, emphasis, and discursive meaning—as well as multiple levels of social identity and indexation (Scotton & Ury 1977; Auer 1995; 1998; 2005; Zentella 1997; Hall & Níle 2015, a.o.). Crucially, these levels of linguistic and social meaning encoded by code-switching are plainly absent and overall unavailable from the alternation between the two different agreement patterns in the utterances in (14) and (15), which is further evidence against adopting any approach that assumes code-switching to explain the optionality of agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses.

Fortunately, it is not necessary to rely on either the multiple-grammars or featural-variation approaches (to the degree that they can be functionally distinguished from one another) within a Minimalist framework to explain this point of intraspeaker variation. It is not even necessary to invoke an economy-based explanation, as in Biberauer & Richards (2006). We now move on to proposing a novel system within the SMT that can handle such cases of agreement optionality within a single grammar, which we consider theoretically advantageous over analyses that necessarily invoke additional mechanisms such as multiple grammars—without compelling evidence to do so—for its simplicity and greater empirical coverage.

⁵ While code-switching between a main clause and a tag-question is clearly possible, it strikes us that some kind of experimental evidence would be needed to confirm if code-switching in a coordinated VP structure in which two verbs of different tenses share both a structural subject and a postverbal argument as in (15) is indeed grammatical or attested.

4.2. Intraspeaker variation in the SMT

The question remains: how, then, do we go about capturing optional agreement within a single grammatical system when it is necessary to do so? Here, we adopt the core proposals of the SMT (Chomsky et al. 2019; Chomsky 2021; 2024).

Foremost, we seek in our explanations here the simplest account of UG possible. On this, Chomsky (2015) states the following.

- (16) ‘Naturally, one seeks the simplest account of UG. One reason is just normal science: it has long been understood that simplicity of theory is essentially the same as depth of explanation. But for language there is an extra reason: UG is the theory of the biological endowment of the language faculty, and each complication of UG therefore poses a barrier to some eventual account of the origin of language, to the extent that this can be attained.’ (Chomsky 2015:3-4)

Thus, in accordance with seeking maximally simplicity, we adopt the following goals in our explanations.

- (17) *Goals of genuine explanation of UG* (Chomsky 2021:12)
- a. It must be rich enough to overcome the problem of poverty of stimulus (POS), the fact that what is acquired demonstrably lies far beyond the evidence available.
 - b. It must be simple enough to have evolved under the conditions of human evolution.
 - c. It must be the same for all possible languages, given commonality of UG.

Given the complications discussed above concerning acquisition and the modeling of a theory of grammar that we find in the multiple-grammar and featural-variation approaches to intraspeaker optionality in NYC English existential agreement with 3pl associates, we formulate here a novel approach to explaining the agreement optionality that does adopt the aforementioned explanatory complications.

We discuss a single grammatical system in which the only structure-building operation is simplest Merge (Chomsky 2013; 2021; 2024; Collins 2017; Chomsky et al. 2019), in accordance with the SMT. As the name suggests, simplest Merge is maximally simple and thus applies freely, as opposed to being driven by an array of abstract selectional features (as in Adger 2003; Koenenman & Zeijlstra 2017, a.o.) (Chomsky et al. 2019:237-8).

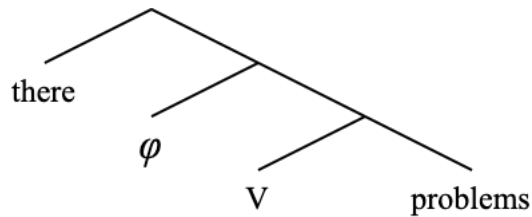
Having only simplest Merge as a structure-building operation, one may become concerned that constraining the possible set of acceptable linguistic utterances becomes a massive enterprise, since we no longer have strict selection-governed restrictions on what is or is not added into a given combinatoric sequence. As we go on to show, however, moving away from such categorical selectional ‘rules’ whose violations lead to strict ungrammaticality is precisely what allows us to conceive of the possibility of optionality within a single grammatical system. On this, Chomsky et al. (2019) state the following:

- (18) ‘Merge thus applies freely, generating expressions that receive whatever interpretation they are assigned by interfacing systems. Surface stimuli deriving from the objects constructed by I-language can have any degree of perceived “acceptability” or “deviance,” from perfect naturalness to complete unintelligibility. Since Chomsky 1955 it has been recognized that no independently given notion of “well-formedness” exists for natural language in the way it is stipulated for artificial symbolic systems (Chomsky

& Lasnik 1993:508). Consequently, concerns about “overgeneration” in core syntax are unfounded; the only empirical criterion is that the grammar associate each syntactic object generated to a <SEM,PHON> pair in a way that corresponds to the knowledge of the native speaker. In fact, “overgeneration” must be permitted on purely empirical grounds, since “deviant” expressions are systematically used in all kinds of ways.’ (Chomsky et al. 2019:238)

Let us see now how we can capture the parameters of optional agreement for 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses in this system. If we (perhaps circularly) define a subject as a given nominal that is a candidate for subject-verb agreement (that is, we do not need to worry for now about the possibility of subject-verb agreement happening with an object⁶), then it stands to reason that existential *there* clauses have two subjects: a structural—i.e., preverbal—subject *there*, and a postverbal associate subject. Crucially, *there* must end up in the position of the structural subject and the associate must remain in the postverbal position. There are numerous analyses of how this situation comes to be (e.g., Chomsky 1995; Moro 1997; Deal 2009; Storment 2025), and we do not find it necessary at this time to commit to one analysis over the other: what crucially matters for us is that *there* ends up as the structural subject while the associate remains in the postverbal subject position. As such, we can envision the following (greatly simplified) structure of an existential *there* clause with a 3pl associate, in which φ represents the head that encodes subject-verb agreement and V represents the verb.

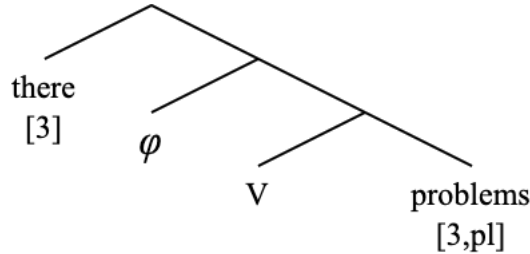
(19) Basic schema of existential *there* clauses



Now, assuming straightforwardly that the person and number features of the associate *problems* are third person and plural, respectively, and following others who have analyzed the existential *there* element as lacking a number feature altogether and being specified only as third person (Chomsky 1981; 2001; Béjar 2003; Deal 2009; Tsiakmakis & Espinal 2022; Storment 2025), we can add the following information into the structure.

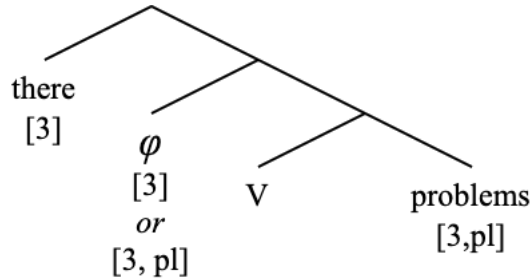
⁶ There are many ways to ensure that objects are not normally accessible for subject-verb agreement, such as encoding locality constraints (e.g., via phasehood) into the domain of subject-verb agreement to thereby make thematic internal arguments too far away from the subject-verb inflectional domain to participate in that kind of agreement.

- (20) Basic schema of existential *there* clauses, with featural information on the subjects



In this configuration, we have two options for the agreement features that can be reflected in the subject-verb agreement relation: third person singular agreement, or third person plural agreement. Assuming that singular agreement is deficiently represented as no number feature at all (Harley & Ritter 2002; Béjar 2003, a.o.), we end up with the following options for agreement:

- (21) Options for subject-verb agreement features



Here, when the head ϕ contains only a third person feature [3], it indexes the featural makeup of the structural subject, whereas it indexes the features of the associate when it contains both a third person feature and a plural feature [3,pl]. Crucially, whether or not ϕ is realized with a plural feature does not mean that the underlying featural specification of the lexical item ϕ should be any different in either case. Rather, the difference comes down to whether or not a given feature is merged into the inflectional domain (in this case represented as a plural feature on the head ϕ ⁷). In other words, we do not need to posit two underlying lexical items ϕ_1 and ϕ_2 in (20) and (21).

Thus, the two options for subject-verb agreement are: to merge a plural feature into the inflectional domain (represented as ϕ), or to not do so. Both options are freely available within a single grammatical system so long as they are able to be interpreted by the interfacing systems (18). Given that agreement in this system is not driven by unvalued probing features whose ‘satisfaction’ can affect the well-formedness of a derivation (e.g., Chomsky 2000; 2001), we expect nothing to go wrong when a plural feature that could be realized on ϕ is not realized in a given derivation.

⁷ There are certainly multiple ways of representing how features are added into the inflectional domain. If we were to adhere to the Principle of Decompositionality (Kayne 2005) (which is probably ultimately most desirable, given that the sole structure-building operation in the SMT is Merge), we could represent the features of the inflectional domain as distinct heads: one head for Num, and another for Pers. In this case, the lack of having merged a plural feature would be represented not as the absence of feature on a head ϕ , but as the lack of a dedicated head Pers altogether. We do not pursue this style of representation here for the sake of simplicity, and the most crucial bit of information to keep in mind is that these features are added into a derivation via simplest Merge either way.

It should not be the case, though, that anything goes in terms of agreement in these configurations (or in any configuration). Obviously, subject-verb agreement is something that most of the time only has one licit realization: indeed, these existential constructions are notable in that they have more than one acceptable agreement form. While the unconstrained nature of simplest Merge easily accommodates variable agreement patterns when they come up, it is perhaps less obvious how to rule out impossible/unattested patterns in this framework. Fortunately, though, unattested patterns can indeed be ruled out. In order to explain this, we should bear in mind the nature of subject-verb agreement in the first place, as well as some considerations on the way in which derivations are interpreted by the interfacing systems, specifically the Conceptual-Intentional (C-I) interface (a.k.a. LF) (Chomsky 2021; 2024).

There is an obvious question of why agreement exists in the first place. For a simple answer to this question, we can turn to Miyagawa (2010).

- (22) *Purpose of agreement* (Miyagawa 2010:9)
Agreement occurs to establish a functional relation.

In other words, the ‘point’ of subject-verb agreement is more-or-less to keep a record of the functional relation(s) that exist between a verb and whatever argument it is indexing (usually, the subject). In most cases, there is only one subject, so the number of arguments that a verb needs to keep track of in subject-verb agreement verb agreement does not exceed one (hence one option in most configurations for agreement). In existential *there* clauses, however, there is more than one subject argument involved: the structural subject and the ‘thematic’ subject, so to speak.

Agreement—i.e., the by-product of some such operation as Minimal Search (Ke 2019; 2023; Krivochen 2023; Roberts 2024; Collins 2025)—can then be described as a kind of matching condition that holds between (in this case) the verb and the subject(s). In either option for agreement with 3pl associates in existentials (21), this matching function of agreement is realized with both the structural subject *there* and the associate. We explain this now.

In (21), in the case of third person singular agreement features [3] on φ , there is a strict matching relation between the features on φ and the features of *there*, which is also [3]: [3] = [3]. Additionally, the features of φ constitute a proper subset of the features of the 3pl postverbal associate: [3] $\subset$ [3,pl] (i.e., there are no mismatched features). Therefore, matching holds between φ and both arguments.

Similarly, when φ has third person plural agreement features [3,pl], there is a strict matching relation between the features of φ and the features of the 3pl postverbal associate [3,pl]. As well, the features of *there* [3] constitute a proper subset of the features of φ : [3] $\subset$ [3,pl] (again, there is no mismatch).

These considerations allow us to capture the impossibility of agreement in the following example, as well as why person agreement mismatches are generally not permitted in English (which is not to say that person mismatches can never arise under a particular set of circumstances), since $1p \neq 2p \neq 3p$: i.e., there would be conflicting ‘values’ for the same feature class.

- (23) *There am a problem.

Ultimately, these considerations on matching should be tied to conditions on the ability of a given derivation to be assigned an interpretation at the C-I interface—see again (18). Extra

agreement features which do not match any relevant element in the agreement domain—such as a first person feature in (23)—create an issue of interpretation as they do not index any element that is present in the derivation⁸. Thus, the violation of the purpose of agreement (22) via featural mismatches is avoided in natural language grammars as it does not have a salient interpretation: how is a first person agreement feature interpreted in the lack of a first person argument?

We still must contend, however, with the fact that number agreement mismatches are still relatively restricted. For example, it is not possible to have plural agreement [3,pl] on φ in existential *there* clauses with a singular associate, even though we have just described [3,pl] as not creating a mismatch with an element that bears the feature [3].

- (24) a. *There are a problem.
b. *There have arrived a man.

Ruling out the agreement pattern in (24) turns out to be relatively straightforward. One could say that, unlike with the number-deficient existential *there*, the singular associates in (24) actually contain a syntactically-projected singular feature [sg], in which case a mismatch is created between [3,pl] on φ and [3,sg] on the associate, thus creating an issue of interpretation of the verbal agreement features (what are they referring to, since they are not indexing any argument that is present in the clause?).

Alternatively, without getting into the weeds of the deficient versus explicit representation of singular number features, it can equally suffice to simply state that the availability of a ‘superfluous’ (with respect to the structural subject) plural agreement feature, even when it may not necessarily create a featural mismatch anywhere, is not going to be able to be assigned a licit interpretation if it does not identify any argument that is present in the clause.

There is still one pattern of ungrammatical agreement related to these existential clauses to contend with. While variable number agreement is possible with 3pl postverbal associates in existential clauses, the same 3pl arguments in preverbal position tend to trigger obligatory agreement. We observe the following contrast in the relevant language variety:

- (25) a. There {has/have} arrived three men at the party.
b. Three men {have/*has} arrived at the party.

How to rule out a lack of number agreement between φ and a preverbal 3pl subject is less straightforward, since a structural subject with the features [3,pl] and a φ with the featural makeup [3] does not create a mismatch in the sense that we have defined here. There is still a contrast, though, between the following examples.

- (26) a. There have arrived three men.
b. *Three men has arrived.

Despite the obvious contrast in acceptability, both of the sentences in (26) contain an asymmetry in number between the structural subject and the featural makeup of φ : in the (a)

⁸ It is worth mentioning that this kind of matching condition on interpretation can be implemented without Agree as an independently stated operation (as it is in Chomsky 2000; 2001, a.m.o.). On alternatives that use Minimal Search in a way that is totally divorced from Agree and instead relies on the SMT-compliant notion of Form Copy, see Blümel (2023); Roberts (2024); Collins (2025); Storment (2026).

example, the structural subject *there* has the featural makeup [3] while φ has the features [3,pl]; in the (b) example, the structural subject *three men* has the features [3,pl] while φ has [3]. While these asymmetries seem more-or-less equivalent, they lead to acceptability in one instance (a) and unacceptability in another (b).

Crucially, the difference between (a) and (b) in (26) is that, in (a), the structural subject is not the only argument: there is also a postverbal associate subject which does indeed have all of the features found on φ ([3,pl]). In the (b) example, the structural subject *three men* is the only subject—and indeed the only argument—in the clause. Thus, in (b), while a φ composed of only the feature [3] may not create a featural mismatch with the structural subject, it fails to completely match in features with any element in the clause. Additionally, φ does not completely match the features of the structural subject: it contains fewer features than the structural subject.

In (a), however, φ does completely match in features with the structural subject *there* (φ contains more features than the structural subject here, not fewer), in addition to containing a plural feature that indexes the postverbal associate. We can state these considerations in the following condition.

(27) *Condition on agreement with the structural subject*

In any configuration, the features of the structural subject must be equivalent to or a proper subset of the features of subject-verb agreement φ . Additionally, any feature on φ that is not present on the structural subject must identify another element in the subject-verb agreement domain.

Thus, a ‘superfluous’ plural feature is only licit if it identifies some argument that is actually present in the domain of agreement. Further, it seems to be the case that the features of the verbal inflectional domain φ must exhaustively match the features of the structural subject: either containing just as many or more features than are actually present on the structural subject, but not fewer. We believe that this kind of exhaustivity condition on matching could easily be subsumed under third-factor principles of computational efficiency (Chomsky 2021) in the SMT.

Ultimately, either realization of agreement in (25a) fully identifies some argument that is present in the subject agreement domain, whereas the ungrammatical agreement pattern in (25b) fails to fully identify any argument that is present in the clause (though it partially identifies one). We believe that this contrast can further be connected to considerations on the role of agreement in the C-I interface within the SMT. Within the SMT-based framework described here, any option for agreement is available in the narrow syntax as long as it is able to be assigned a licit interpretation at the C-I interface, and it happens that English existential *there* clauses with 3pl associates have two options for agreement that have licit interpretations (whereas an example such as (25b) only has one). Crucially, multiple grammars are not necessary to accomplish this.

Additionally, Chomsky (2013; 2015) argues that a structural subject must fully match in features with the inflectional agreement head φ (referred to elsewhere as T, though we do not want to assume that the head responsible for agreement inflection is necessarily the same as the one that encodes tense information) in order for both elements to be visible to the Labeling Algorithm, which is an interpretive mechanism invoked in the C-I interface (Collins 2002; 2017; Seely 2006; Chomsky 2013; 2015; Collins & Stabler 2016). While we do not pursue a discussion of labeling in detail here, we believe that this is a promising avenue of exploration for casting the proposals here in a formal system, and we leave doing so for future work.

In the following section, we turn to a discussion of extragrammatical factors in shaping language users' preferences of use surrounding options that are equally allowed within the narrow syntax in variable agreement with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses in NYC English.

4.3. The explanatory role of extragrammatical preferences

The existence of equally-available optional realizations of some structural configuration in the narrow syntax—i.e., what we see with acceptability—does not necessarily guarantee that each optional realization should be equivalent in terms of use and value, nor is that a prediction of the considerations laid out in the previous section. In fact, the data obtained in our corpus study (Section 3.3) clearly show that these optional realizations are not equivalent in terms of use.

We should consider here the role that socially- or individually-conditioned preferences play in the potential realization of syntactic utterances, and what kind of explanatory role (if any) these kinds of preferences concerning variation should have in a Minimalist syntactic framework, thereby connecting variation more explicitly to syntactic theory (MacKenzie & Robinson 2026).

In the SMT-based system sketched above, the narrow syntax is exceptionally bare in terms of the kinds of operations it performs and the kinds of information that can be represented within it. Thus, it is likely that any preferences that language users have around the use of grammatical forms generated by the narrow syntax are not actually encoded into the syntactic derivations themselves. Instead, language users' preferences are best conceived of as conditions that speakers impose over items that are freely generated by a computational system composed only of simplest Merge.

In other words, language users showing a preference for singular agreement in present tense existential *there* constructions with 3pl associates does not mean that the narrow syntax itself has a preference encoded into it for producing singular agreement a majority of the time (indeed, this seems incompatible with the notions of optionality and of simplest Merge); rather, speakers form preferences over options that are freely generated by simplest Merge. For these reasons, we refer to these kinds of preferences as *extragrammatical*.

These preferences could conceivably operate over any aspect of the realization of existential clauses: for instance, we could expect speakers to have a preference for one agreement realization over the other based on any of the factors discussed in Section 2 such as associate type (2), verb tense (3), verb type (4), and so on, even though none of these factors have a notable effect on whether or not the utterances are acceptable/grammatical.

Regarding tense, our corpus data demonstrate that present-tense constructions favor singular agreement and exhibit relatively weak speaker-level conditioning, whereas past-tense constructions show substantially greater clustering by speaker, which is to say that preferences for singular agreement in the present tense are more diffuse across the speech community and preferences for singular agreement in the past tense are more individualized. These observations suggest that language users have different preferences for agreement realization based on tense. Rather than claiming that language users have distinct grammars for each tense, we assert that these results show distinct conditions on the preferences that speakers may exhibit across tenses.

For instance, singular agreement in the present tense may be favored across the speech community to a higher degree than it is in the past tense because singular agreement in English with the existential copula allows for the realization of the contracted form -'s, which speakers may favor for its phonological efficiency (Lowe & Wu 2026) and the fact that it causes the verbal element to be more adjacent to the source of singular agreement—existential *there*—than it is to the associate, since it is cliticized onto the structural subject.

On this, we may also expect to see agreement preferences based on linear order. For example, plural agreement with a 3pl associate may be more strongly favored when it is structurally adjacent to the verb: e.g., without subject raising (6) or an intervener (7). These kinds of factors influencing language users' realizations of variable agreement have been discussed elsewhere for similar configurations in other languages, such as Icelandic (Kučerová 2016) and for Spanish (Ormazabal & Romero 2024; Gallego 2025).

In any of these cases, we observe a divergence between what language users may accept as grammatical and what language users are actually producing, and to what extent. For example, we note grammatical agreement optionality across a variety of constructions in Section 2, though such free optionality in terms of acceptability does not mean speakers should have totally equivalent frequencies of use concerning both optional variants. This distinction can be connected to the documented fact that language users are known to accept more variants than they actually produce themselves (Fischer et al. 2022).

Ideally, any proposed extragrammatical preferences that govern the individual or socially-conditioned use of optional realizations allowed in the narrow syntax should be connected to third-factor principles—e.g., of computational efficiency (Chomsky 2021:12)—in SMT-based explanations of the nature of the human language faculty. For instance, a preference for a contracted singular form can be clearly connected to principles of efficiency in production, and a preference for agreement that is affected by linear order and adjacency can be clearly connected to principles of efficiency in parsing (i.e., comprehension).

The existence of these preferences, and the fact that they may be socially-conditioned and thus display associations with social predictors, can prove useful in explaining phenomena such as the age-grading effects seen with the use of certain linguistic forms. Here, the observation that language users' preferences are not fixed and may undergo change overtime (Hughes 1992) is certainly relevant. In this way, we can connect younger language users' preferences for nonstandard linguistic forms to a variety of demographic factors without necessarily positing the existence of multiple grammars to explain this single point of variation.

Ultimately, we can go further to consider why there should be intraspeaker optionality within a single grammatical system in the first place, and why there are preferences governing the use of these options for individuals and for speech communities. We connect these questions to what is called the *enabling function* of the SMT (Chomsky 2021; Chomsky et al. 2023), by which variable functions are assigned to different options and systems generated within the computational system of a language user's grammar. As it is relevant for our purposes here, when simplest Merge allows for more than one interpretable realization of a given utterance, those different options which are both equally acceptable are enabled to be utilized by individuals and speech communities in distinct ways that can be shaped by preferences ultimately governed by third-factor principles of computational and evolutionary efficiency.

Thus, the SMT provides us with a novel framework for understanding cases of intraspeaker optionality, such as what we see with variable agreement with 3pl associates of existential *there* clauses in NYC English, that cannot be cleanly connected to language change and/or the existence of multiple competing grammars. We understand that simplest Merge allows for more than one interpretable realization of subject-verb agreement in these clausal configurations, and that the enabling function of the SMT along with third-factor principles allow for language users and speech communities to exhibit preferences around the use of optionally available forms generated via simplest Merge.

5. Conclusion

In this paper, we have discussed in detail the case of optional agreement realization with 3pl associates in existential *there* clauses in NYC English. Motivated by evidence from native speaker grammaticality judgments and (crucially) a corpus study using the CUNY-CoNYCE corpus, we show that speakers of this English dialect largely have both plural and singular agreement with 3pl associates freely available to them, in a way that is not connected to an active process of language change or the convergence of multiple competing grammars.

Based on our judgments and corpus study results, as well as some outstanding issues with multiple-grammars-based accounts of these kinds of intraspeaker optionality, we have described a novel explanation of intraspeaker optionality based in the SMT, driven exclusively by simplest Merge and the ability of a given derivation to be interpreted at the C-I interface. We have additionally explained how this system allows for language users to exhibit preferences over optional forms that are equally realized within the same system.

Moving forward, we believe that this theoretical framework can be applied to other English language varieties that exhibit the same parameters of variable agreement in existential clauses (see Storment 2025), as well as similar cases of agreement optionality that appear in certain configurations in other languages, so long as it can be shown that there is sufficient reason to believe that a given instance of intraspeaker optionality is not the result of multilectalism. This framework is valuable in that it provides tools for modeling intraspeaker optionality in a way that is not necessarily connected to language change and multilectalism.

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